

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Philemon 1:1

- *Paul, a prisoner*: People traditionally believe the apostle Paul wrote from prison in Rome. However, he might have written earlier from Ephesus, which is closer to Philemon's home in Colosse (see Philemon Book Introduction, "Date and Place of Writing").
- *Timothy*: He was one of Paul's closest fellow workers (see "Timothy" Profile).
- *fellow worker*: Philemon was active in ministry for Christ.

Philemon 1:1-3

Paul usually begins with a short introduction followed by greetings and the invocation of grace and peace.

Philemon 1:2

This is not a private letter to Philemon alone but is addressed also to his family and church. • Apphia was probably Philemon's wife. • soldier: The servant of Christ is involved in a war and must be prepared to stand firm in the face of opposition ([Eph 6:10-17](#)). • Archippus was probably Philemon's son (also mentioned in [Col 4:17](#)). • the church that meets in your house: The early Christians met together in private homes (see also [Rom 16:5](#); [1 Cor 16:19](#); [Col 4:15](#)).

Philemon 1:3

You is plural, referring to all those mentioned in [1:2](#). • Grace and peace represent traditional Greek and Hebrew greetings, respectively; they are now understood as gifts from God (cp. [Rom 5:1-2](#)).

Philemon 1:4-7

In his letters, Paul usually thanks God for the faith and love of his readers and mentions his prayers for them ([Rom 1:8-12](#); [1 Cor 1:4-9](#); [2 Cor 1:3-11](#); contrast [Gal 1:6-10](#)). Ancient Greek letters occasionally included a section of thanksgiving following the greeting.

Philemon 1:5

It is by faith in Christ that we are saved, and it is by love for fellow Christians that we live out our salvation.

Philemon 1:6

This verse can be translated in different ways. Paul is hinting that Philemon should be gracious toward Onesimus in light of God's goodness to Philemon (cp. [1:10](#), [17-19](#)).

Philemon 1:8-9

- The apostle Paul asked for a favor because Philemon was well-known as a kind and loving person ([1:5-7](#)). Paul could have used his authority as an apostle of Christ to demand it, but he chose to ask out of love.
- *I, Paul, am now aged*: Paul appealed to the respect owed to older people and his status as *a prisoner for Christ Jesus*, which would increase a fellow Christian's respect.

Philemon 1:10

show kindness: In the Roman world, runaway slaves could be treated harshly with whipping, branding, or even execution, at the owner's discretion. • Onesimus was Paul's spiritual child because he became a believer through Paul's ministry.

Philemon 1:11

Onesimus means “useful.” • hasn’t been of much use (literally *useless*) . . . very useful: This might be a play on words (cp. [1:20](#)). Onesimus was now serving others and proclaiming the Good News. At last he had become what his name means.

Philemon 1:13–14

Paul hints at his desire that Philemon choose to free Onesimus to serve as Paul’s helper (also [1:21](#)). The Christian life is a free response to God’s grace ([Rom 12:1](#); [Eph 4:1](#); [Col 3:12–13](#)).

Philemon 1:15

you lost Onesimus (literally *he went away*): This might be a euphemism for running away, in order not to mention Onesimus’s offense directly. • so that you could have him back forever: It is implied that God providentially arranged events to lead to Onesimus’s salvation.

Philemon 1:16

Though Onesimus was still legally Philemon’s slave, Philemon must think of him as a beloved brother and be committed to his well-being. • both as a man and as a brother in the Lord: Brotherhood in Christ must now transform their whole relationship in both the natural and spiritual realms.

Philemon 1:18

Onesimus might have stolen some things from Philemon’s home or had a debt to pay off when he ran away.

Philemon 1:19

Paul guarantees his promise with his signature. He typically dictated his letters to a secretary; on occasion, as here, he wrote something in his own hand. • your very soul: That is, his salvation. Philemon owed Paul much more than anything

Onesimus might have owed him. Whether this means Philemon was converted directly or indirectly through Paul’s preaching is not clear (cp. [Col 1:7](#)).

Philemon 1:20

do me this favor: Or *let me have this benefit*; Greek *onaimēn* (“favor, benefit”) might be a play on the name Onesimus, which can mean “beneficial” (cp. [1:11](#)).

Philemon 1:21

and even more: Paul might be hinting that he would like to see Onesimus released (cp. [1:13–14](#)), or he might simply be expressing confidence in Philemon’s kindness.

Philemon 1:22

Paul’s request for a guest room in anticipation of his visit reinforces his request that Philemon treat Onesimus kindly. At his coming, he would see how Onesimus had been treated.

Philemon 1:23

Epaphras was a native of Colosse who first brought the Good News to Philemon and his family ([Col 1:7](#); [4:12](#)).

Philemon 1:23–25

Paul usually closes his letters with greetings from others and a benediction. Cp. [Col 4:7–18](#); Paul’s letters to the Colossians and to Philemon were probably carried to Colosse at the same time by Tychicus and Onesimus.

Philemon 1:24

These men are also mentioned at the end of Colossians ([Col 4:10, 14](#)). • co-workers: They helped Paul spread the Good News. • Mark: See “John Mark” Profile. • Aristarchus was a faithful associate of Paul for many years ([Acts 19:29](#); [20:4](#);

[27:2](#)). • Demas was a co-worker who later abandoned Paul ([2 Tim 4:10](#)). • Luke: See “Luke” Profile.